Mahid M. Mutilan

Dr. Mahid M. Mutilan (1943 – December 6, 2007) was a Maranao scholar, politician, peace advocate, and religious leader from Tamparan in Lanao del Sur, Philippines. He served three consecutive terms as Governor of Lanao del Sur from 1992 to 2001, and later as Vice-Governor of the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM). Before entering politics, he spent more than a decade as a Muslim missionary in Japan, building bridges between cultures and faiths long before "interfaith dialogue" became a catchphrase in Philippine governance.

What made Mutilan unusual, even in a region full of remarkable figures, was how completely he defied the mold. In Lanao del Sur, political power had long been the exclusive territory of entrenched dynasties. Mutilan came in with something different: a doctorate from Al-Azhar University in Cairo, a platform built on Islamic principles, and a genuine belief that governance could be guided by moral accountability rather than lineage. He called his movement **Ompia**, the Maranao word for reform, and the name said everything about his vision.

He is perhaps remembered most widely as a co-founder of the Bishops-Ulama Conference (BUC), the landmark body that brought together Catholic bishops, Protestant leaders, and Muslim scholars to work toward peace in Mindanao. His death on December 6, 2007, in a vehicular accident just one day after what would be his final public address, cut short a life that had been fully dedicated to reconciliation, education, and the upliftment of the Bangsamoro people.

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Early Life and Background

Mahid Mutilan was born in 1943 in the municipality of Tamparan, a predominantly Maranao community sitting along the shores of Lake Lanao in Lanao del Sur. He grew up in a region where Islamic tradition ran deep, where the Ulama (religious scholars) carried enormous moral authority, and where political power was heavily tied to one's family name.

From early on, it was clear that Mutilan wasn't going to follow a conventional path. He had an appetite for learning that went well beyond what was available locally, and he pursued his education with the kind of seriousness that would eventually take him thousands of miles from home, all the way to one of the most prestigious Islamic institutions in the world.

Education

Mutilan earned his **Doctorate in Islamic Theology** from Al-Azhar University in Cairo, Egypt. At the time of his graduation, he was among a very small number of Filipinos to have attained that level of religious academic distinction from Al-Azhar, an institution founded in 970 CE and widely regarded as the foremost authority in Sunni Islam.

His education at Al-Azhar didn't just give him credentials. It gave him a worldview. He came back not only as a deeply trained faqih (Islamic jurist) but also as someone who had seen how Muslim communities could engage with the wider world without losing their identity. That perspective shaped everything he would do afterward, from his missionary work to his political career.

Missionary Work in Japan

Before politics ever entered the picture, Mutilan served as a Muslim missionary in Japan for somewhere between eleven and nineteen years, a stretch of time that tells you a great deal about his patience and his commitment. Japan is not an easy place to do religious outreach. It's a society with deep cultural cohesion, and Islamic communities there have historically been small and scattered.

Mutilan's work in Japan centered on intercultural dialogue and the construction of Islamic centers, physical spaces where Muslims in Japan could gather, pray, and feel a sense of community. This wasn't just charity work. It was the beginning of a lifelong practice: finding common ground across difference, and building institutions that could outlast any single person's efforts.

When he eventually returned to the Philippines, he brought that same instinct with him. And Lanao del Sur, a region caught between entrenched tradition and urgent need for change, gave him a much larger stage.

Dr. Mahid M. Mutilan



Born	1943 Tamparan, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Died	December 6, 2007 (aged 63–64) Gitagum, Misamis Oriental, Philippines
Cause of death	Vehicular accident
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Political party	Ompia Party
Spouse(s)	Not publicly documented
Alma mater	Al-Azhar University, Cairo, Egypt
Known for	Three-term Governor of Lanao del Sur; co-founder of the Bishops-Ulama Conference; founder of the Ompia (Reform) movement; ARMM Education Secretary
Title	Governor; Vice-Governor; Grand Mufti (honorific)

Political Career

Term of office	Governor: 1992–2001 Vice-Governor, ARMM: 2001

The Ompia Movement

By the late 1980s, the political landscape of Lanao del Sur was, bluntly, a closed system. Traditional Maranao leadership, the datus and their extended clans, held political power as something close to a birthright. Elections happened, but they largely shuffled influence within the same social circles. The idea that an Ulama-backed movement could break through was, to most observers, far-fetched.

Mutilan proved them wrong.

He founded the **Ompia Party**, taking its name directly from the Maranao word for reform. The party's platform was built around Islamic populism, which in practical terms meant: moral governance, public accountability, and a shift away from clan loyalty as the basis of political support. He didn't campaign against any specific family. He campaigned against the entire system of governance that put lineage above competence and loyalty above integrity.

The voters of Lanao del Sur responded.

Mayor of Marawi City (1988–1992)

Mutilan's first major electoral win came in 1988, when he was elected Mayor of Marawi City, the regional center of Lanao del Sur and the only predominantly Islamic city in the Philippines. His term as mayor gave him a platform to demonstrate what the Ompia platform actually looked like in practice: attention to basic services, an emphasis on education, and a governing style informed by Islamic ethical principles rather than transactional politics.

His mayoralty also gave him the credibility and name recognition to aim higher.

Governor of Lanao del Sur (1992–2001)

In 1992, Mutilan won the governorship of Lanao del Sur, a victory that signaled a genuine shift in the province's political culture. He would go on to win re-election twice, serving three consecutive terms through 2001.

During his tenure as governor, his administration was guided by the same convictions that powered the Ompia movement. He pushed the Ulama into a more active role in public affairs, not as figures who blessed whoever happened to be in power, but as genuine stakeholders in the direction of the province. By doing so, he created a new kind of political accountability, one rooted in Islamic moral authority rather than clan hierarchy.

His governorship coincided with some of the most turbulent years in the Mindanao peace process, and he used his position to engage consistently with national-level discussions about the future of Muslim Mindanao.

ARMM Vice-Governorship and Educational Reform

In 2001, Mutilan stepped into regional leadership as the **Vice-Governor of the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao** (ARMM), serving alongside Governor Parouk Hussin. Alongside that role, he served concurrently as the **ARMM Secretary of Education**, a portfolio that he approached with characteristic seriousness.

His most significant push during this period was the effort to integrate the **Madaris curriculum** (the curriculum of traditional Islamic schools) into the standard Philippine educational framework. For decades, Muslim students in the region had faced a stark and unnecessary choice: religious education or secular education. Mutilan pushed back

against that false choice. He wanted Muslim students to receive a solid grounding in both Islamic studies and the broader academic subjects that would prepare them for university and professional life.

This wasn't purely an educational vision. It was a political one too. A generation of Bangsamoro youth that was both religiously grounded and academically equipped would be far less vulnerable to radicalization and far more capable of participating in governance, law, medicine, and other fields where the region desperately needed local expertise.

His tenure wasn't free of difficulty. One persistent challenge was the non-remittance of GSIS (Government Service Insurance System) premiums for regional teachers, a systemic problem embedded in the ARMM's bureaucratic structure that proved difficult to untangle despite his efforts. It's worth acknowledging that reform at scale is rarely clean, and Mutilan was working inside one of the most complex administrative environments in the Philippine government.

Architect of Peace and Interfaith Dialogue

If there is one aspect of Mutilan's career that transcended the local and spoke to something national, even universal, it was his role as a peacemaker.

Bishops-Ulama Conference

In 1996, Mutilan co-founded the **Bishops-Ulama Conference** (BUC), a historic initiative that brought together Catholic bishops, Protestant leaders, and Muslim scholars in a shared commitment to reducing religious tensions in Mindanao and building a culture of mutual respect between communities that had, in many cases, been living in fear of each other for decades.

The BUC was not a ceremonial body. It did real work: facilitating dialogue in conflict-affected areas, issuing joint statements at critical moments, and providing a platform where religious leaders from different traditions could speak to their own communities with credibility about the importance of coexistence.

Mutilan's involvement in the BUC was entirely consistent with everything else he stood for. He never saw Islam as something to be defended by pushing others away. He saw it as a tradition rich enough to engage with the world generously and honestly.

Peace Negotiations with the MILF

Mutilan also served as a member of the government's peace panel during the administration of President Joseph Estrada, working as a moderate bridge between the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF) and the Republic of the Philippines. His role was not simply representational. He brought to the table the kind of credibility that comes from being genuinely trusted by the Muslim community, someone the MILF leadership could recognize as a serious interlocutor rather than a government mouthpiece.

His participation in these negotiations reflected his core conviction: that the Bangsamoro struggle was not a conflict between religions, but between neglect and justice, between indifference and recognition. He held that position consistently throughout his public life.

Recognition and Legacy

Mutilan is often referred to posthumously as a **Grand Mufti**, though this was an honorific recognition of his scholarly stature rather than a formally appointed title. The designation reflects how his peers and the broader Muslim community in the Philippines regarded him: as someone whose religious knowledge and moral authority were of a genuinely senior order.

The continued existence of the Bishops-Ulama Conference is the most visible institutional legacy of his work. The BUC has outlasted many of the political arrangements that surrounded its founding, and it continues to function as a venue for interfaith engagement in Mindanao.

The integration of the Madrasah curriculum into the Bangsamoro educational system, while still a work in progress long after his death, traces a direct line back to the advocacy he led during his time as ARMM Education Secretary.

In Lanao del Sur, his legacy is more personal. He changed the terms of political competition in the province, demonstrating that a candidate could win, govern, and win again, if the platform was honest and the commitment was real.

Death

On **December 6, 2007**, Dr. Mahid M. Mutilan died in a vehicular accident in Gitagum, Misamis Oriental, while he was traveling to catch a flight to Manila. He was 63 or 64 years old.

The accident came just one day after what would be his final public address, delivered in Marawi City on December 5, 2007. In that speech, he spoke about peace, about the obligations of faith, and about justice. Those who were present described it as a summation of everything he had spent his life saying.

His death was mourned across the Philippines. Leaders from the Muslim and Christian communities alike offered condolences. The loss was felt not just as the passing of a politician or a scholar, but as the removal of a voice that had, for decades, argued consistently and credibly for a better way of doing things in a region that desperately needed exactly that.

> "Islam is a religion of peace. Our struggle is not against people of other faiths, but against injustice and the neglect of our moral responsibilities."
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> — Dr. Mahid M. Mutilan, Final Public Address, Marawi City, December 5, 2007

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Further Reading

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See Also

- Bishops-Ulama Conference
- Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Lanao del Sur
- Marawi City
- Moro Islamic Liberation Front
- Bangsamoro
- Al-Azhar University
- Madrasah education in the Philippines
- Parouk Hussin
- Maranao people
- Lake Lanao

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